

Chapter 3 – Old Testament Song

After two chapters of introduction, it is time to begin the historical narrative. But before we can explore the origins of hymnody, we'll have to go back to before the first Christian hymns were ever written. Before the Church ever wrote hymns in the way we recognize them today, she first had to learn how to pray the Scriptures in song. In other words, before Christians sang about Christ in *hymns*, they first learned how to sing *Scripture* in light of Christ.

It's tempting to imagine a clean break, as though Christianity suddenly invented a new musical genre after the death and resurrection of Jesus. But the reality is far more organic. The Church inherited a sung prayer tradition that was already centuries old. The ancient Israelites had always prayed in song – the psalms being the most famous example.

Ancient Near-Eastern Poetry

Much of the Old Testament is written in some sort of poetic form. If we think about the layout of the books of the Old Testament, we'll see it begins with the Pentateuch (the five books of the law), continues with the books of history, followed by the books of poetry, and finally concludes with the major and minor prophets. The books of poetry – Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Solomon, Wisdom of Solomon, and Sirach – make up a significant portion of the Old Testament.

There are also several canticles in various other segments of the Old Testament, such as Moses's song of praise after pharaoh's army and chariots were cast into the sea (Ex. 15:1-18), and Hannah's prayer for the birth of her son Samuel (I Sam. 2:1-10).

In English, these pieces don't really read like traditional poetry. They don't rhyme and they don't seem to fit a common syllable meter, like a hymn. However, you'll notice that, even in English translations of the Bible, these pieces are often indented and written line-by-line. The Old Testament was not written in a vacuum, nor was it written according to modern Western ideas of poetry.

Instead, much of it belongs to what scholars call **Ancient Near-Eastern poetry**. This form of writing is not shaped by rhyme or meter, but by comparison, contrast, repetition, and an overall heightened speech. These literary devices are well-suited for prayer since they invite the listener to slow down and reflect on the deeper meanings of the text rather than on exact argument. Let's look through some of the more common techniques used in Ancient Near-Eastern poetry that should still be familiar to us today.

The first few techniques all fall under the broad category of comparison. The first of these is **metaphor**. A metaphor is a comparison between two things without using the words "like" or "as." We can think here of Psalm 23, "The Lord is my shepherd." God is not *literally* a shepherd, but the image teaches us that He is shepherd-like. A shepherd leads, protects, feeds, and stays close to the flock. That's a metaphor.

Closely related is **simile**, which makes a comparison more explicitly using the words "like" or "as." Psalm 42 opens, "As the deer longs for flowing streams, so my soul longs for you, O God." Similes like this one are especially effective because they invite us to imagine an image before we interpret it.

Another common technique is **personification**. Personification is similar to metaphor in that it makes a comparison without explicit connecting words, but it differs in that it attributes

human behavior to something non-human. Psalm 96 tells us that “the heavens rejoice, the earth is glad... the trees of the forest sing for joy.” Here, creation itself is portrayed as worshiping God like humans. So then when Israel sings these words, the people learn to see their own praise as part of something in harmony with the rest of creation.

Ancient Near-Eastern poetry also relies heavily on **contrast**. Psalm 1 sets this pattern: “The Lord knows the way of the just, but the way of the wicked leads to ruin.” The righteous and the wicked are placed side by side so that the listener can be confronted by the stark differences between them. Contrast reveals clarity.

Repetition is perhaps the most important technique of all for sung prayer. (How many times do we sing “Alleluia” in every Easter hymn we encounter?) Psalm 136 is the best example of this. Every line in Psalm 136 ends in the phrase “for his mercy endures forever.” By the time the psalm ends, the congregation has been trained to hear all of Israel’s history in light of God’s mercy.

Finally, the psalms make frequent use of **hyperbole**, or deliberate exaggeration. In Psalm 3, the psalmist declares, “I do not fear, though thousands are arrayed against me.” The hyperbole here allows the psalmist to express intense emotion in language large enough to carry it.

To see all 6 of these techniques in practice, below is an example of Psalm 19. Refer to the color-coded chart to see where each literary device appears:

Literary Device	Color
Metaphor	Red
Simile	Orange
Personification	Yellow
Contrast	Green
Repetition	Blue
Hyperbole	Purple

Psalm 19 New American Bible

The heavens declare the glory of God;
the firmament proclaims the works of his hands.

Day unto day pours forth speech;
night unto night whispers knowledge.

There is no speech, no words;
their voice is not heard;

A report goes forth through all the earth,
their messages, to the ends of the world.
He has pitched in them a tent for the sun;

it comes forth like a bridegroom from his canopy,
and like a hero joyfully runs its course.

From one end of the heavens it comes forth;
its course runs through to the other;
nothing escapes its heat.

The law of the Lord is perfect,
refreshing the soul.
The decree of the Lord is trustworthy,
giving wisdom to the simple.

The precepts of the Lord are right,
rejoicing the heart.
The command of the Lord is clear,
enlightening the eye.

The fear of the Lord is pure,
enduring forever.
The statutes of the Lord are true,
all of them just;

More desirable than gold,
than a hoard of purest gold,
Sweeter also than honey
or drippings from the comb.

By them your servant is warned;
obeying them brings much reward.

Who can detect trespasses?
Cleanse me from my inadvertent sins.

Also from arrogant ones restrain your servant;
let them never control me.
Then shall I be blameless,
innocent of grave sin.

Let the words of my mouth be acceptable,

the thoughts of my heart before you,
Lord, my rock and my redeemer.

Psalm Types

Now that we've looked at the literary devices of Old Testament poetry, we can take a step back and ask how these psalms were actually used in worship. Just as we identified different voices in hymnody last week – doxological, doctrinal, allegorical, and experiential – the psalms themselves also fall into recognizable categories. These are not rigid boxes, and many psalms overlap more than one type. But each category highlights a particular way the people of Israel learned to speak to God in prayer.

One of the most common categories is **praise**. Psalms of praise are oriented outward and upward. They glorify God for who He is and for what He has done. Psalm 103 is a classic example. It opens with the words, “Bless the Lord, my soul; all my being, bless His holy name.” The focus is not on the individual praying, but on God Himself. In that sense, psalms of praise function very much like doxological hymns: they train the worshiper to look beyond the self and to give God glory simply because He is worthy of it.

Another important category is **wisdom** psalms. These psalms reflect on God's law and the way of life that flows from them. Psalm 119 is the most famous example, and it's also the longest psalm in the whole Psalter. One familiar line from it reads, “Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light for my path.” Wisdom psalms teach the worshiper how to live rightly by placing God's instruction at the center of daily life.

In contrast, **penitential** psalms give voice to sorrow for sin and the plea for mercy. The most well-known of these is Psalm 51. It opens with the cry, “Have mercy on me, God, in accord with your merciful love; in your abundant compassion blot out my transgressions.” This type of psalm teaches the faithful how to repent – not by despairing, but by trusting in God's compassion.

Closely related, but distinct, are **lament** psalms. These psalms often begin with distress, almost appearing to be hostile or untrusting toward God. Psalm 22 begins with one of the most striking lines in all of Scripture: “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” Lament psalms are often uncomfortable for us to read in Scripture because they speak to God honestly about pain and seem to question if He's even there. But still they are great acts of faith because they continue to address God even in distress.

There are also **processional** psalms, or psalms associated with movement, pilgrimage, and public worship. Psalm 132 gives us a glimpse into this world: “Let us enter His dwelling; let us worship at His footstool. Arise, O Lord, come to Your resting place, You and Your mighty ark.” These psalms were likely sung during festivals, as the people journeyed toward the temple or as sacred objects were brought into God's presence. They remind us that worship in Israel was physical and communal. In other words, they are liturgical.

Psalm Type	Explanation	Example
Praise	A type of psalm focused on glorifying God for who He is and what He has done.	Psalm 103 - “Bless the Lord, my soul; all my being, bless His holy name.”
Wisdom	A type of psalm that reflects on	Psalm 119 - “Your word is a lamp for

	God's law and teaches the way of righteous living.	my feet, a light for my path."
Penitential	A type of psalm expressing sorrow for sin and a plea for mercy.	Psalm 51 - "Have mercy on me, God, in accord with your merciful love; in your abundant compassion blot out my transgressions."
Lament	A type of psalm that cries out in suffering while still addressing God in faith.	Psalm 22 - "My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?"
Proclamation	A type of psalm associated with movement, pilgrimage, or communal worship.	Psalm 132 - "Let us enter His dwelling; let us worship at His footstool. Arise, O Lord, come to Your resting place, You and Your mighty ark."

There are many more categories we could explore, but that would take us beyond the scope of this book. What matters to the development of hymnody is this: the psalms gave Israel a wide range of emotions in their prayer. So when the early Church inherited these psalms, she inherited this wide array of ways to speak to God.

Singing the Psalms

Before moving forward, it's worth noting briefly that these psalms were not only written for spoken or individual prayer, but sung in very specific ways by multiple people.

Sometimes the psalms were **chanted**, which means the text was lifted above ordinary speech to mark it as sacred. In all forms of chant, the rhythm of the words determine the musical rhythm so that the words themselves are prioritized over the music. We will talk more about chant and how the Christian church inherited this tradition in Chapter 5.

At other times, psalms were sung **responsorially**, with a leader proclaiming the verses and the people responding with a repeated line. This allowed the entire community to participate, even if not everyone knew the whole psalm by heart. This is the primary way that the psalms are used during the Mass – a leader or cantor proclaims the verses while the congregation responds with a refrain. Additionally, many hymns, especially those written within the latter half of the 20th century, are written with this form. In some settings, psalms were sung **antiphonally**, with two groups alternating verses. Scripture becomes a kind of dialogue within the assembly. This is a common way that psalms are recited during the recitation of the Divine Office in many convents and monasteries.

All three forms assume the same thing: the language of God's people is prayer. And it is appropriate for that language to be proclaimed within the community and elevated through song. And it is precisely this sung, prayed Scripture that Christians would soon reinterpret following the Incarnation of Christ.

Chapter 3 Resources

Glossary of Terms:

- **Ancient Near-Eastern poetry** – A form of biblical poetry that relies on comparison, contrast, repetition, and elevated speech rather than rhyme or meter.
- **Metaphor** – A comparison between two unlike things without using “like” or “as,” used to reveal deeper meaning.
- **Simile** – A comparison using “like” or “as,” inviting the listener to visualize before interpreting.
- **Personification** – A comparison attributing human qualities to non-human things.
- **Contrast** – Placing opposing ideas side-by-side to highlight stark differences between them.
- **Repetition** – The intentional reuse of words or phrases to reinforce meaning.
- **Hyperbole** – Deliberate exaggeration used to express strong emotion or emphasize truth.
- **Praise** – A type of psalm focused on glorifying God for who He is and what He has done.
- **Wisdom** – A type of psalm that reflects on God’s law and teaches the way of righteous living.
- **Penitential** – A type of psalm expressing sorrow for sin and a plea for mercy.
- **Lament** – A type of psalm that cries out in suffering while still addressing God in faith.
- **Processional** – A type of psalm associated with movement, pilgrimage, or communal worship.
- **Chanted** – A method of singing where speech is elevated and governs the melody.
- **Responsorial** – A form of singing where a leader proclaims verses and the people respond with a repeated refrain.
- **Antiphonal** – A form of singing where two groups alternate verses or phrases.

Discussion Questions:

1. How do the literary devices of Ancient Near-Eastern poetry shape the way Scripture is heard out loud rather than simply read? How might this differ from how we typically understand Scripture today?
2. Many psalms speak with bold emotional honesty, even to the point of questioning God (as in Psalm 22). Why might this kind of language be essential for faithful prayer rather than a sign of weak faith?
3. How does the use of imagery (shepherd, king, rock, light) in the psalms prepare the way for later Christian hymnody centered on Christ?
4. In what ways do the psalms already contain the seeds of doxological, doctrinal, allegorical, and experiential hymnody?
5. The chapter identifies several types of psalms. Which of these types do you notice most often in the psalms used at Mass?
6. Consider your favorite psalm. What Ancient Near-Eastern literary devices does it use? What type of psalm might it be?

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Chapter 4 – Early Church Song

Up to this point in the historical narrative of this book, we've focused on Israel's song. In the Old Testament, prayer is shaped around God's mighty actions on behalf of Israel – creation, covenant, deliverance, guidance, and promise. But when we cross into the New Testament, something happens: the **Incarnation**. God takes on human flesh.

This is the great turning point of all of salvation history. God's saving work is no longer only depicted as something to be anticipated or as some events from long ago that are distantly remembered. God is present, embodied, and visible. From this moment forward, the song of God's people will not simply speak about God's past actions for our ancestors nor does it anticipate the future fulfillment of His covenants, but rather His present actions for us through, with, and in Jesus Christ. Once Christ enters history, He becomes the center of worship.

This focus is what makes the Christian musical tradition distinct. The Church still sings the same psalms as David, but she sings them knowing who the Messiah is and what He came to do.

New Testament Canticles

Nowhere is this shift more clearly expressed than in the opening chapters of Luke's Gospel. Luke preserves four canticles. These are sung, poetic texts that are deeply rooted in the style and language of the Old Testament psalms, but now unmistakably shaped by the arrival of Christ.

The first is the **Magnificat**, Mary's song of praise (Lk. 1:46-55). It begins: "My soul magnifies the Lord, and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior." In this canticle, Mary recognizes that what has taken place within her is the decisive moment of history. In it, Mary has a distinct mindset of "from now on." "From now on all generations will call me blessed." The long waiting of Israel turns, in this moment, into something that has finally been fulfilled.

Likewise, there's the **Benedictus**, the song of Zechariah at the birth of his son, John the Baptist (Lk. 1:68-79). It begins: "Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel, for He has visited and redeemed His people." This song rejoices that God's saving plan is finally unfolding. John is named as the forerunner, the dawn that announces the coming day.

The third canticle is the **Gloria**, sung by the angels at the birth of Jesus: "Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace to people of good will," (Lk. 2:14). This short song draws all attention to the Incarnation. The Incarnation is so important that the host of angels come down to earth to glorify God in the manger where He rests.

Finally, the **Nunc Dimittis** is Simeon's song when he encounters the child Jesus in the temple (Lk. 2:29-32). "Lord, now you let your servant go in peace, according to your word. My own eyes have seen the salvation which you have prepared in the sight of every people." Simeon represents all the faithful of Israel who have waited across generations. And now that he has seen the messiah, he can now rest. The moment that prophets had waited for is here.

There are other canticles in the New Testament as well, in Paul's letters (e.g. Php. 2:6-11) and in the Book of Revelation (e.g. Rev. 5:9-13, 19:1-10). And all of these New Testament canticles are centered on Christ. But Luke's canticles stand as the clearest threshold moment when Old Testament prayer is transformed by the presence of God made flesh. This is now finally the beginning of a distinctly Christian prayer in song. The Church, however, does not stop singing the psalms. But rather, she begins to hear them differently.

The Divine Office

The transition from Jewish worship to Christian worship – from Old Testament prayer to New Testament prayer – hinges entirely on the Incarnation. Because, like as stated above, once Christ enters history, He becomes the center of worship. And so, in the earliest years of the Church, the Church developed the Divine Office. The Divine Office, also known as the Liturgy of the Hours, naturally developed out of the Church’s practice of reciting the psalms and canticles of the Old and New Testaments.

A quick pause. What do I mean by liturgical... what is “**liturgy**”? That is a word that I will be using a lot for the rest of this chapter. Liturgy is the structured, communal prayer of the people of God. It’s structured, meaning there is an order to the things that happen during a liturgy. And it’s communal, meaning that it is ideally done with more than one person.

When we talk about liturgy, many of the Church’s prayers will reference a “heavenly exchange.” God gives us the grace to pray to Him in faith, while we respond by offering Him our worship. And this is especially done through, with, and in Christ. We think especially about the moment during the Mass right after the consecration when the priest elevates the Body and Blood and says, “Through Him, with Him, and in Him, O God, almighty Father, in the unity of the Holy Spirit, all glory and honor is Yours, forever and ever.” Here, we see that our sacrifice is offered through, with, and in Christ, giving glory and honor to the Father, which all happens in the unity of the Holy Spirit.

Most often when we reference specific liturgies, we’re talking about the Divine Office, and of course, the Mass. The structures of these prayers have been authored by the Church, making them official prayers.

The **Divine Office** is the Church’s daily rhythm of prayer. Across the hours of the day – morning, evening, and night – the Church prays the psalms and canticles of Scripture again and again. But the psalms have now taken on a new meaning. Of course, the Church does not rewrite the psalms. But as she reads the psalms, she reads them in view of the work of Christ.

Psalm 23 is a perfect example. The psalmist wrote, “The Lord is my shepherd,” but the Church now hears that line in light of Christ’s words: “I am the good shepherd.” Compare it to the original psalm text. Take note of some of the changes that reinterpret the psalm in view of Christ.

Psalm 23 <i>New American Bible</i>	“The King of Love My Shepherd Is” Text: Henry Williams Baker, 1868 Tune: ST. COLUMBA, Irish, 1906
The Lord is my shepherd; there is nothing I lack	1. The king of love my shepherd is, whose goodness faileth never. I nothing lack if I am His, and He is mine forever.
In green pastures He makes me lie down; to still waters He leads me;	2. Where streams of living water flow, my ransomed soul He leadeth and, where the verdant pastures grow, with food celestial feedeth.
He restores my soul.	3. Perverse and foolish, oft I strayed,

He guides me along right paths for the sake of His name.	but yet, in love, He sought me and on His shoulder gently laid and home, rejoicing, brought me.
Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff comfort me.	4. In death's dark vale I fear no ill with Thee, dear Lord, beside me; Thy rod and staff, my comfort still, Thy cross before to guide me.
You set a table before me in front of my enemies; You anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows.	5. Thou spreadst a table in my sight; Thine unction grace bestoweth; and oh, what transport of delight from Thy pure chalice floweth!
Indeed, goodness and mercy will pursue me all the days of my life; I will dwell in the house of the Lord for endless days.	6. And so, through all the length of days, Thy goodness faileth never; good shepherd, may I sing Thy praise within Thy house forever.

The Divine Office also focuses on a distinctly Christian prayer by giving special attention to the canticles that mark the Incarnation itself, especially those found in Luke's Gospel. At morning prayer, or Lauds, the Church sings the Benedictus, Zechariah's song. Each morning begins by remembering that the "dawn" of salvation has already come. At evening prayer, or Vespers, the Church sings the Magnificat, Mary's song. As the day comes to a close, the Church stands with Mary, magnifying the Lord. And at night prayer, Compline, the Church sings the Nunc Dimittis. Like Simeon, the faithful entrust themselves to God at the end of the day, confident that they have seen salvation through Christ and can rest in peace.

Over time, this constant praying of Scripture reshapes how the Church hears it. And it is from the habitual practice of prayer that Christian hymnody will begin to grow.

Greek Hymnody

In the fourth century, the Church historian St. Eusebius quoted **St. Hippolytus of Rome** (who lived around the year 200) who asked, "Who does not know about ... all the psalms and hymns that were written by faithful Christians from the beginning, which sing of the Christ as the Word of God and treat Him as God?" This quotation teaches us two things. First, that the Church was writing its own hymns from its very beginning. Second, that these hymns were notably Christocentric.

The early Church was, at first, primarily a Greek-speaking community. Christianity spread through the eastern Mediterranean long before it became established in Rome. And because of that, the earliest original Christian hymns we know about were written in Greek, not Latin. We do not possess many of these earliest texts in complete form. However, many Scripture scholars believe that certain passages in the New Testament itself are actually fragments of early Christian hymns. A well-known example is Philippians chapter 2 which appears to preserve a hymn celebrating Christ's humility and exaltation. Similar hymn-like fragments appear in the writings of early

Church figures such as Ignatius of Antioch, who likely died around the year 140, and even in very early Christian documents like the *Didache*, probably written near the end of the first century.

What all of this suggests is that Christian hymnody did not suddenly appear centuries later. It grew organically out of the Church's earliest worship life, shaped by theology and sung prayer.

The earliest fully recognizable Christian hymn that we still possess is the *Phos Hilaron*, often called the "Candle-lighting Hymn." This hymn was used at Vespers, or evening prayer, specifically at the moment when lamps or candles were lit. Its text praises Christ as the radiant light of the Father, worshiped together with the Holy Spirit. What is important here is not only the beauty of the text, but its liturgical function. This hymn was not written for private devotion or artistic display. It was written to accompany a concrete ritual action within the Church's liturgy.

This is an important detail, since it reminds us that much of the Church's earliest music was inseparable from the liturgy itself. Hymns arose not because Christians wanted more songs, but because worship demanded words that could be sung.

Let's take a look now at one of the standard English translations of this hymn, taken from our *Gather* hymnals, "O Radiant Light, O Sun Divine."

Liturgy of the Mass

Liturgical song in the early Church was not limited to the Divine Office. Christians have always sung the Mass. What has changed over time is not whether the Mass is sung, but which liturgical form is being sung.

Today, in the Roman Catholic Church, we celebrate what is commonly called the *Novus Ordo Mass*, which dates to the reforms of the 1960s. Before that, the Tridentine form of the Mass was codified in 1570. And before that, there existed a variety of pre-Tridentine liturgical forms. In the first centuries of Christianity, different regions used different liturgies, all sharing a common structure but differing in details.

The oldest Eucharistic liturgy that we know of by name is the Liturgy of St. James, which is traditionally attributed to St. James the Less, one of the apostles. What is remarkable is that this liturgy is still used today by some Eastern Christian communities.

One of the most familiar hymns connected to this liturgy is the hymn "Let All Mortal Flesh Keep Silence." This text is a translation of the offertory prayer from the Liturgy of St. James, sung as bread and wine are prepared for the Eucharist. Take note of how the theology of the Incarnation, the awe of Christ's presence, and the union of heaven and earth are all compressed into a single sung prayer.

It was also during these early centuries that the **Ordinary of the Mass** took shape – the common texts that remain the same every Sunday. These include the Kyrie, the Gloria, the Credo, the Sanctus, and the Agnus Dei. By around the year 600, all five of these elements were firmly established in the liturgy. What is especially important for us to recognize is that these texts were sung by the entire congregation, not reserved for choirs or clergy alone. With the exception of the Kyrie, which remained in Greek, these texts were sung in Latin, because Latin had become the common language of the people as Christianity spread throughout the Roman Empire.

We won't linger on these texts, especially since they don't function as "hymns" necessarily. But they form the liturgical environment in which hymnody will soon take on an even sharper role. And that brings us to the crisis that would shape Latin hymnody forever: the rise of Arianism – and the response of St. Ambrose of Milan.

Latin Hymns and Heresy

For roughly the first three centuries of Christianity, the Church in the West lived under periodic persecution. Christian communities met quietly, often privately, and public worship was limited by necessity. Because of this, Western hymnody developed more slowly than it did in the Greek-speaking East. But that changed dramatically in the early fourth century. With the Edict of Milan in 313 under the reign of **St. Constantine**, Christianity became legally tolerated within the Roman Empire. Almost overnight, Christian worship moved from secrecy into public space. Churches were built, congregations gathered openly, and Christians were able to break out into song.

Chapter 1 establishes that a hymn has to *say something*. It must carry theological substance. Well, the early Church learned this lesson very quickly. And this is of course a good thing! But, only if it's used to teach *correct* doctrine.

In the early fourth century, one of the most influential theological movements the Church faced was Arianism, as it was propagated by an Alexandrian priest named **Arius**. Arius taught that Jesus Christ, the son of God, was not eternal – that He was *created* by the Father, and that there was a time when He did not exist. This heretical teaching seemed to make sense, and it spread rapidly, not only through sermons and arguments, but through song. Arian communities composed hymns that were easy to sing and easy to remember. These hymns subtly trained people to think of Christ as less than God.

St. Ambrose

Into this moment steps **St. Ambrose**, bishop of Milan and one of the most influential figures in Western Christianity. Ambrose is often called the “Father of Hymnody” – not because he was the first Christian hymn writer, but because of how decisively he shaped what hymnody would become in the Latin Church.

What made Ambrose's hymns so influential was not novelty, but accessibility. He paired clear, orthodox theology with simple, regular poetic form. His hymns were written in what we now call Long Meter, with a steady 8.8.8.8 rhythm that congregations could easily follow. These were hymns meant to be sung together by a congregation in unison.

Although Ambrose wrote many hymns, only four can be confidently attributed to him today. Even so, those surviving texts tell us a great deal:

- They are deeply Trinitarian,
- They are unmistakably Christological,
- And they were written for liturgy, either the Divine Office or the Mass.

Ambrose understood that hymns could teach doctrine as effectively as any homily – sometimes more so. And, when they're used to teach correct doctrine, they are used as a way to sort of “battle” unorthodox doctrines, or heresies.

There is a well-known story from the year 386 during a conflict with the Arian-leaning emperor **Valentinian II**. Ambrose was celebrating Mass with his congregation in the Milan Cathedral when Valentinian surrounded the cathedral with an army, barricading Ambrose and his congregation inside. Valentinian demanded that Ambrose give him one of the Christian churches in

Milan to be used for Arian worship. Ambrose refused to cede to the Arians, however, and the army kept the congregation inside for several days. However, when the congregation started singing their Christological hymns, the power of their voices singing in unison unsettled the Arian soldiers who retreated in fear.

Ambrose's critics accused him of "bewitching" his people with his hymn melodies. Ambrose replied that he did not deny it. Hymns, he insisted, were meant to move the heart so that truth could take root there.

Ambrosian Style Hymns

One of the most distinctive features of Ambrose's hymnody is how his hymns end. Ambrose regularly concluded his hymns with a Trinitarian doxology – a final verse giving equal praise to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. By ending prayer in the name of the Trinity, he reinforced that Christ is worshiped with the Father and the Spirit, not beneath them. This practice stands in direct contradiction to Arian teaching, called the **Lesser Doxology**. And this practice still survives today, too. Consider how many hymns end in something like:

All praise to God the Father,
all praise to God the Son,
all praise to God the Spirit,
eternal three-in-one!

Probably the most popular of Ambrose's 4 surviving hymns is *Veni Redemptor Gentium*, which was used as a case study in Chapter 1. This is a hymn that seems to have been written for Advent. We will now listen to one of the English translations, the one that appears in the *Gather* hymnals, "Savior of the Nations Come." As we listen, take note of the Trinitarian and Christocentric theology that it teaches.

Over time, Ambrose's style became a model. After his death in 397, other Christians began writing hymns in the same metrical, theological style. Soon, the term "**Ambrosian hymn**" was used not only for Ambrose's own works, but for Latin metrical hymns in general. By the sixth century, **St. Benedict of Nursia** started to refer to *all* hymns used in the Divine Office simply as ambrosianum, even the ones that weren't written by Ambrose himself. The style had become standard.

One of the best-known hymns in this tradition is "At the Lamb's High Feast We Sing." It brings together Scripture, doctrine, and liturgical praise in precisely the way Ambrose helped establish. Let us sing that together now.

Tonight we've seen that Christian hymnody grows out of Scripture already shaped for prayer. When Christ entered history, the psalms were not replaced but re-heard, now centered on Him, and through daily liturgy they became a way of learning doctrine through prayer.

Chapter 4 Resources

Glossary of Terms:

- **Incarnation** – The mystery of God taking on human flesh in the person of Jesus Christ, marking the turning point of salvation history and the center of Christian worship.
- **Magnificat** – Mary’s song of praise (Luke 1:46–55), proclaiming the fulfillment of God’s promises, often sung at Vespers (Evening Prayer).
- **Benedictus** – Zechariah’s canticle (Luke 1:68–79), announcing the dawn of salvation through Christ, often sung at Lauds (Morning Prayer).
- **Gloria** – The angelic hymn at Christ’s birth (Luke 2:14), giving glory to God at His Incarnation.
- **Nunc Dimittis** – Simeon’s song (Luke 2:29–32), expressing fulfillment and readiness for rest after seeing the Messiah, often sung at Compline (Night Prayer).
- **Liturgy** – The structured, communal prayer of the Church, offered through, with, and in Christ.
- **Divine Office** – The Church’s daily cycle of prayer (Liturgy of the Hours), centered on psalms and canticles interpreted in light of Christ.
- **Phos Hilaron** – A Greek hymn, and the earliest recorded Christian hymn, written for Vespers during the lighting of lamps.
- **Ordinary of the Mass** – The fixed texts of the Mass (*Kyrie, Gloria, Credo, Sanctus, Agnus Dei*) that remain constant.
- **Lesser Doxology** – A short Trinitarian formula of praise placed by St. Ambrose at the end of his hymns, affirming the full divinity of the Trinity.
- **“Ambrosian hymn”** – A Latin metrical hymn in the style established by St. Ambrose: written in 8.8.8.8 meter using the doctrinal voice and ending in a Lesser Doxology.

Notable Figures:

- **St. Hippolytus of Rome** (170–235) – Early Christian writer who attests to the existence of Christian hymnody in the Church’s earliest worship.
- **St. Constantine** (272–337) – Roman emperor whose Edict of Milan in 313 AD legalized Christianity, allowing public liturgical development.
- **Arius** (256–336) – Alexandrian priest whose denial of Christ’s full divinity spread widely through teaching and hymnody.
- **St. Ambrose** (339–397) – Bishop and “Father of Latin hymnody,” who used congregational hymn singing to teach orthodox Trinitarian doctrine.
- **Valentinian II** (371–392) – Roman emperor associated with Arian sympathies, involved in conflict with Ambrose over church control.
- **St. Benedict of Nursia** (480–547) – Founder of Western monasticism who standardized the use of hymns within the Divine Office.

Discussion Questions:

1. How do the canticles in Luke’s Gospel both continue the style of Old Testament psalms and transform them through the presence of Christ?
2. The chapter describes the Incarnation as the turning point of sung prayer. How does Christian worship differ when God is no longer only remembered or anticipated, but present?

3. Early Christian hymnody was inseparable from liturgical action (as seen in the *Phos Hilaron*). What is gained when music is tied directly to ritual, and what is lost?
4. Arianism spread in part through simple, memorable hymns. What does this suggest about the power of music to shape belief, for better or for worse?
5. How does St. Ambrose's approach to hymn writing (Trinitarian, Christological, and liturgical) respond directly to the theological confusion of his time?

Hymns for Further Study:

- "The King of Love My Shepherd Is" – paraphrase of Psalm 23 demonstrating how certain imagery can become Christological in hymnody
- "Out of the Depths I Cry to Thee" – setting of Psalm 130 reinterpreted in light of Christ's atonement
- "O Radiant Light, O Sun Divine" – translation of the early Greek hymn the *Phos Hilaron* (also known as the "Candlelighting hymn") illustrating the union of liturgical action and sung theology
- "Let All Mortal Flesh Keep Silence" – rooted in the offertory rite of the Liturgy of St. James, demonstrating the Eucharistic and incarnational focus of early liturgical song
- "Savior of the Nations, Come" – translation of Ambrose's famous Advent hymn *Veni, Redemptor Gentium*, expressing clear Christological doctrine in response to heresy
- "Maker of All, Eternal King" – translation of Ambrose's evening hymn *Aeterne Rerum Conditor*, reflecting his liturgical focus, ordered structure, and Trinitarian theology
- "At the Lamb's High Feast We Sing" – later Latin hymn in Ambrosian style, integrating Scripture, liturgy, and Trinitarian praise

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